Enterprise Agents and the Frontier Labs

Where to focus in AI agents that finish enterprise work, judged by the budget that pays for the work and by what OpenAI and Anthropic will take for themselves

1. Key takeaways

The theme covers AI agents that finish a defined piece of enterprise work, such as working a denied medical claim or clearing a purchase order exception, and the software that runs them. For every company we ask which budget pays for the work and whether OpenAI or Anthropic will take that work for themselves. The five takeaways below tell the story in order, from where the money is to where we would and would not invest.

1. **The money for agents that finish work comes from the labor budget, which is several times the software budget and is moving to business owners outside IT**
   - Companies spend far more on the people and outsourcers who do their work than on the software those people use, and every published estimate agrees on the size of the gap. Sequoia estimates that six dollars go to services for every dollar spent on software (Sequoia), Felicis finds labor budgets run 35 times software budgets (Felicis), and US government data counts 17,753,430 office and administrative support workers at a mean wage of $51,560 (BLS).
   - That labor spending is already being repriced, because agents now do part of the work that outsourcers used to bill for by the hour or by the head. HFS expects agent-delivered services to become a $422 billion segment inside the outsourcing market (HFS Research), and a contact center outsourcing executive says the rate his firm can charge fell 20% to 40% in two years (expert call).
   - The person who signs for this spend increasingly sits in the business and compares an agent with the outsourcer's invoice rather than with another software license. BCG finds that more than 80% of AI spending now sits outside enterprise IT (BCG), and Sequoia points out that moving an outsourcing contract to an AI provider is a simple change of vendor, while cutting headcount means reorganizing the company (Sequoia).
   - For us, the best companies sell the finished job to the operations owner and get paid out of the labor line, which is a bigger budget and a different buyer from the IT seats the labs mostly sell today.
2. **Almost every big enterprise now runs agents, but few can show a return yet, so a company wins by proving results in the customer's own numbers**
   - Agent use has spread across big companies quickly and keeps compounding on the main enterprise platforms from one quarter to the next. In a July 2026 survey 95.3% of enterprises ran at least one agent workflow in production (IDC), and Microsoft counts over 50M agents in its registry, up more than 30% in a quarter (Microsoft earnings call).
   - The value has not kept pace with the usage, because most agents still do simple, narrow tasks that are hard to tie to a line in the budget. Only 13% of CIOs report significant or transformational value from AI (Gartner), only 22% of organizations have scaled AI across multiple business units (Gartner), and the head of Amazon Web Services describes most enterprise agents as relatively simple and mostly non-autonomous (AWS interview).
   - Buyers therefore stay wary of savings claims and keep paying the way they always have. Decision makers still rank per-seat pricing first at 42.3%, ahead of consumption at 36.6% and outcome pricing at 21.1% (Futurum), ServiceNow's finance chief says its customers are not asking for outcome pricing at all (ServiceNow earnings call), and a revenue cycle executive whose own gains are in the low double digits dismisses any vendor claim above that (expert call).
   - For us, a company does not need outcome pricing to sell finished work, but it does need named customers running it in production and results that show up in the customer's own records.

3. **Since January the labs have moved from selling models to selling the agent runtime, ready-made department agents and their own deployment services**
    - The software that runs agents, which agent platforms used to sell, now comes from the labs at close to the cost of the tokens it uses. Anthropic launched Managed Agents at $0.08 per session-hour in April (Anthropic), and OpenAI opened its Agents API in September with no fees beyond tokens and tools (OpenAI).
    - Both labs also ship ready-made agents for whole departments that take a goal through to finished documents and analyses. Anthropic open-sourced 11 Cowork plugins for roles from sales and finance to legal and customer support in January (Anthropic), and OpenAI launched ChatGPT Work in July as an agent that turns a goal into finished work (OpenAI).
    - To get those agents into production the labs are adding people as well as products, and they are only now building the services arms that reach the labor budget. OpenAI formed a majority-owned deployment company with more than $4B of initial investment (OpenAI), Anthropic formed a services firm with Blackstone, Hellman & Friedman and Goldman Sachs aimed at mid-sized companies (Anthropic), OpenAI's Frontier Alliances bring in BCG, McKinsey, Accenture and Capgemini to deploy its platform (OpenAI), and AI companies bought 195 other AI companies through September 29, with OpenAI making 10 of those deals and Anthropic 5 (Crunchbase via Forbes).
    - For us, anything generic is now a lab feature, so a company whose product is the runtime, a department template or a generic context layer has to compete with a lab that gives it away.
4. **The labs leave the work that needs private data, write access to core systems, a license or liability, and that is where vertical companies keep their price**
    - Lab products stop at the template and leave the buyer responsible for the outcome, because running a regulated or messy operation is slow, local and risky work. Sapphire Ventures finds that the labs do not want to take on the operational mess of running work for customers (Sapphire Ventures), and Andrej Karpathy points builders to work that is valuable and easy to check but that the frontier labs have not trained their models on (conference summary).
    - A company that does the work also keeps the data from doing it, which makes each new job cheaper to deliver and harder for a rival to copy. Bessemer argues that each delivered unit of verifiable work becomes training data for the company that delivers it (Bessemer), and Menlo Ventures finds that regulatory certification and human sign-off slow competitors down (Menlo Ventures).
    - Our category research in Part 2 finds this gap open in health plan administration, in insurance below the biggest carriers, and in procurement and freight, where the labs have shipped tools but nobody has taken the accountable work. In bank compliance, life sciences research and finance operations the labs and their partners now sell the core tool, so we would back only the narrow work they leave alone, such as outsourced compliance review, experiments run on a drug company's own data and filings a provider answers for.
5. **We would stay out of legal services and customer service, and back horizontal platforms only when they run the work and stay neutral across models**
    - In legal services and customer service the labs and the big software suites now sell the agents and the finished work directly, and lab engineers already build tools inside the biggest law firms. A new company in either market competes with the labs, with the incumbents built on them and with the firms they equip, so we would use customer service only as the benchmark for what finished work costs.
    - Horizontal platforms still have room, because big buyers spread their bets across models and want to keep control of their own agents. In a survey 81% of big-company CIOs use three or more model families (a16z CIO survey), and 67% of agent platform users expect the control plane to sit at least partly outside a provider-managed service (VentureBeat survey).

- For us, the bar for a horizontal platform is high, because one that only builds or governs agents is selling what the labs now include for free, so we would back only the few that deliver the work themselves and stay neutral.

2. Interesting categories: where to focus

We split the theme into horizontal software that runs agents across a company, regulated verticals where a license or rulebook governs the work, and non-regulated verticals where the work is operational. Each area is judged on the budget it draws on and on what OpenAI, Anthropic, Microsoft and Google shipped there since January 2026. Where the labs now sell the finished work themselves, or put their own engineers inside the firms that already do the accountable work, we would not focus there. Where they ship tools but leave the accountable work to someone else, the category stays open.

A. Horizontal

A1. Orchestration and Execution Platforms

- **Tailwinds: Companies are handing agents real authority faster than they build the controls, which leaves room for a neutral layer that runs and records the work.** In a BCG survey of 1,330 executives, 42% expect agents to hold real decision authority by 2030 while only 5% have the controls in place (BCG).
- **Headwinds: Every lab and cloud now ships the generic runtime and control plane for agents, so a company selling only that layer has nothing the labs do not already give away.** OpenAI launched Frontier in February with HP, Oracle, State Farm, Thermo Fisher and Uber as first adopters (OpenAI), Google turned Vertex AI into the Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform in April (Google), and Microsoft sells Agent 365 to govern agents at $15 per user per month (Microsoft).
- **Custom agent systems built by outside engineers rarely last, which hurts any platform sold as a build project.** Gartner expects 70% of enterprises to abandon agent systems built by vendor engineering teams by 2028 because of maintenance costs (Gartner).
- **Why we should focus here selectively: We should back a horizontal platform only when it runs the work itself across many processes, gets paid from the operations budget and works with any model or cloud.** A platform that resells the runtime or control plane has to beat the labs on price, and the labs give that layer away.

Example companies: Duvo, Sycamore

A2. Work Context

- **Tailwinds: Enterprises expect to tailor agents to how their own business works, which needs context that no model ships with.** In a Deloitte survey of 3,235 leaders, 85% expect to customize agents to fit the unique needs of their business (Deloitte).
- **Headwinds: The labs now bundle company context into their own platforms at no extra charge.** Frontier includes a business context layer that spans warehouses, CRM, ticketing and internal apps (OpenAI), and Anthropic lets admins package skills and connectors into private plugins for each team (Anthropic).
- **SAP is buying context about how work gets done for its own HR suite, which squeezes anyone selling that context on its own.** SAP agreed to buy a work context graph company for its HR suite (SAP).
- **Why we should focus here selectively: Context is worth backing when a company gathers it by doing the work in a specific process and sells it together with that work.** Context sold as a separate catalog runs into the layers that SAP and the labs now bundle.

Example companies: Edra, Workfabric AI

B. Regulated Verticals

B1. Healthcare Administration

- **Tailwinds: Federal rules now put deadlines and public reporting on prior authorization, so slow manual review becomes a visible cost for health plans.** A CMS rule requires most affected payers to decide within 72 hours for urgent requests and seven calendar days for standard ones from January 1, 2026 (CMS), and practices complete 39 prior authorization requests per physician per week (AMA).
- **Headwinds: Both labs launched healthcare products in January, and Anthropic's includes a sample template for the prior authorization review that health plans run today.** OpenAI launched ChatGPT for Healthcare on January 8 with HCA Healthcare, Cedars-Sinai and UCSF and templates that include prior authorization support (OpenAI), and three days later Claude for Healthcare added a CMS coverage connector and a customizable prior authorization review template (Anthropic).
- **A revenue cycle executive says the dominant health record vendor blocks outside AI at big health systems, which closes the provider side to most new vendors.** The executive says the vendor does not allow outside AI integrations beyond its own work (expert call).
- **Why we should focus here: Health plans pay for each review or claim, carry the liability when one goes wrong and need write access to their own systems, none of which a lab template provides.** We should back companies that sell to health plans, where the record vendor matters least, and that show results in the plan's own numbers.

Example companies: Anterior

B2. Insurance Operations

- **Tailwinds: Insurers employ big claims and policy teams whose work follows forms, rules and deadlines that agents can follow too.** Government data counts 324,230 claims adjusters, examiners and investigators at a mean wage of $80,470 (BLS), and HFS expects traditional outsourcing to "decline from 55% to 37% of delivery" within two years (HFS Research).
- **Headwinds: Anthropic is building claims agents with Allianz and State Farm adopted OpenAI's agent platform early, so the biggest carriers get custom agents straight from the labs.** Allianz is co-developing motor and health claims agents with Anthropic (Allianz), State Farm was among the first adopters of OpenAI Frontier (OpenAI), and the listed insurtech Roadzen is launching underwriting and claims agents on Anthropic's managed agent platform (Roadzen filing).
- **Insurers are pitched constantly and keep their data in house, which makes it easy to switch vendors.** An insurance executive says he hears two or three vendor pitches a day and that all of his data lives inside his existing systems (expert call).
- **Why we should focus here: Neither lab sells a finished insurance product, and below the top carriers the work sits inside licensed agencies, smaller carriers and claims administrators that answer to regulators.** We should back companies that hold the license or run the claim for the insurer, because they get paid like the outsourcer they replace and switching away from them means rebuilding the operation.

Example companies: Notch, Pace, Harper, Strala

B3. Lending and Financial Crime

- **Tailwinds: Financial crime compliance is a big and rising cost whose biggest line is people.** It costs institutions in the US and Canada $61 billion a year, and labor is the biggest cost within that spending (LexisNexis and Forrester).
- **Headwinds: Anthropic and OpenAI now reach banks through the core banking providers, and FIS now sells an AML investigation agent built with Anthropic to every US bank.** FIS made its AML agent, built with an embedded Anthropic team, available to any US bank in October (FIS), Fiserv launched agentOS with OpenAI as a collaborator and an AML triage agent among its four launch agents (Fiserv), and Anthropic's templates include KYC screening (Anthropic).

- **Capital One built its own agent platform, and both labs now sell packages for financial services, so the biggest banks need an outside agent company least.** Capital One built its own agent platform under model risk rules (podcast), and OpenAI built ChatGPT for Financial Services with Morgan Stanley and Evercore (OpenAI).
- **Why we should focus here selectively: The FIS agent only recommends, so the bank still owns every case and the tool layer now comes from the core providers.** Its design partner says "the investigator remains accountable for the final determination" (FIS), so we should back only companies that take over the review work lenders, fintechs and regional banks now outsource and that answer to the examiner for it.

Example companies: Salient, Bretton AI, Gradient Labs

B4. Legal Services

- **Tailwinds: Legal work is a big services budget that buyers already pay per matter or per hour to outside firms.** Speakers at a Sequoia event put legal services alone at about $400B in the US (Sequoia event transcript).
- **Headwinds: Anthropic now sells a full legal product and says legal professionals became the most engaged users of its Cowork agent of any knowledge-work function.** Claude for Legal launched in May with 12 practice-area plugins and more than 20 connectors (Anthropic), and by October Anthropic had added more than 60 legal connectors and a gallery of legal tools built with law firms and PwC (Anthropic).
- **OpenAI followed in September with a legal configuration of its newest model, and its engineers now build custom tools inside the biggest law firms.** Astra for Law ships with a legal search index and 26 partner plugins, and OpenAI's forward-deployed engineers built tools for Sullivan & Cromwell, Ropes & Gray and Cooley (OpenAI).
- **Thomson Reuters rebuilt its CoCounsel product on Anthropic's agent toolkit and also launched a legal model of its own, so the research incumbent now competes on both the lab layer and the product.** It rebuilt CoCounsel on the Claude Agent SDK (Anthropic), and in August it launched Thomson 1.0, a model trained on its legal research content, while Google expanded Gemini Enterprise for legal professionals (Reuters).
- **Why we should not focus here: Both labs, the research incumbents and the biggest law firms are building legal agents on the same models, which leaves little room for a new company to hold its price.** A company that sells legal work under its own license still carries liability the labs avoid, but it now competes with law firms that get custom tools from lab engineers, so we would not focus here.

Example companies: Crosby, Lawhive, EvenUp

B5. Life Sciences Research

- **Tailwinds: Drug research is one of the biggest professional budgets in any industry and keeps growing.** R&D spending at the biggest pharma companies rose to $190Bn in 2024 from $163Bn in 2023 (IQVIA Institute).
- **Headwinds: Both labs now sell research products straight to drug companies, and research software stocks fell on the day Anthropic launched its research workbench.** Anthropic named Novo Nordisk and Sanofi as customers in January (Anthropic), OpenAI launched a life sciences model with Amgen and Moderna in April (OpenAI), and Schrodinger shares fell as much as 8.3% the day Anthropic launched Claude Science in June, with Recursion and IQVIA also lower (trade press).
- **Why we should focus here selectively: Lab workbenches help a drug company's own scientists, while an agent that runs experiments on that company's data for its programs does work the labs leave alone.** Results take years to prove, so we should back only companies that already show repeat paid work at the same drug company.

Example companies: Edison Scientific

C. Non-Regulated Verticals

C1. Procurement, Logistics and Distribution

- **Tailwinds: Purchasing and freight coordination employ big teams whose work runs on email, portals and phone calls.** Government data counts 491,430 buyers and purchasing agents, 202,810 dispatchers outside emergency services and 97,670 cargo and freight agents (BLS).
- **Headwinds: OpenAI is building and testing procurement agents that handle purchasing requests inside a single company, starting with its own finance team.** OpenAI is building a procurement agent with PwC inside its own finance team (OpenAI) and previewed specialist agents tested on procurement and invoice processing in September (OpenAI).
- **ERP suites now ship agents of their own that act inside the purchasing processes they already run.** Oracle launched 22 Fusion Agentic Applications that act inside its business processes (Oracle).
- **Why we should focus here: Those agents handle requests inside one company, while the work we want runs across suppliers, carriers and phone calls outside any single system, where an ERP vendor or a lab agent has no reach.** We should back companies that clear exceptions end to end and can show touchless rates at named manufacturers, freight operators and distributors.

Example companies: Fragment, Magentic, Didero, InstaLILY, BackOps, HappyRobot, Freehand

C2. Finance and Accounting Operations

- **Tailwinds: Finance teams repeat the same work every month with big clerical staffs, and every invoice or reconciliation has a clear count and cost.** Government data counts 1,373,680 bookkeeping, accounting and auditing clerks at a mean wage of $53,560 (BLS).
- **Headwinds: Both labs now go after the in-house monthly close directly, with templates and consulting partners.** Anthropic's spring financial services release includes a month-end closer (Anthropic), and OpenAI and PwC are building agents for planning, payments, tax and the accounting close (OpenAI).
- **Agents cost more to run than the scripted bots finance teams already use, which slows the switch.** An integrator's automation lead says a task costing $200 or $300 a month on bots costs $1,000 or $1,200 a month with AI (expert call).
- **Why we should focus here selectively: The generic close is going to the ERP vendors and the labs, so the opening is in work with its own rules and liability.** We should back companies that serve accounting firms or run global payroll, where the company answers for each filing.

Example companies: Basis, Niural

C3. Customer Service and Sales

- **Tailwinds: Customer service is the first job agents finish end to end at scale, because a resolved ticket is easy to check and to price.** OpenAI says its Presence agent resolves 75% of inbound issues on its own phone line without human assistance (OpenAI), and Salesforce says its agents have handled 4.3 million inquiries on its own help site (CX Today).
- **Headwinds: OpenAI, Microsoft and Salesforce now sell finished customer service work themselves, and Salesforce publishes the price.** OpenAI launched Presence in July as a deployed product for production support agents (OpenAI), Microsoft launched Contact Center Intelligence in October on top of existing systems from Cisco and Avaya (Constellation), and Salesforce charges $2 per resolution for its help agent (CX Today).
- **Why we should not focus here: Customer service is where agents first finished a whole job, so the labs and the software suites moved in first and now set the price.** We should use its resolution rates and prices as the benchmark for other functions and make no new bets here.

Example companies: Sierra, Decagon